

Word family: pair / paired / pairing / pairwise

Base word: pair

Plural: pairs

Verb forms: pair, pairs, paired, pairing

Related forms / useful extensions: pairing, pairwise

Useful compounds/expressions: a pair of, pair up, matched pair, pair programming, pairing food and wine

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞)

Your phrase:

“a **pair of** noise-cancelling headphones”

A full semantic sweep shows that **pair** has one strong central idea:

two things or people considered together because they match, belong together, work together, or form a unit

From that, English develops several useful meanings:

- two matching objects;
- one item made of two joined parts;
- two people together;
- two animals used together;
- verb: combine two things;
- technology: connect devices;
- food/drink: match flavours;
- cards: two equal-ranked cards;
- maths/computing: ordered/unordered pairs.

Meaning in your passage

Here:

a pair of headphones

means:

one complete set of headphones consisting of two earpieces, one for each ear.

繁體中文：一副耳機；由左右兩邊耳罩／耳機部分組成的一整套耳機

Natural translation:

“a pair of noise-cancelling headphones”

= 一副降噪耳機

Important: although **headphones** is grammatically plural, **a pair of headphones** refers to **one complete item/set**.

1. a pair of + matching objects (成對物件) —— 一雙；一對；一副

This is the central noun meaning and your original sense.

Practice 1 — Original

“I bought a **pair of headphones**.”

「我買了一副耳機。」

Practice 2

“She bought a **pair of shoes**.”

「她買了一雙鞋。」

Practice 3

“He was wearing a **pair of gloves**.”

「他戴著一雙手套。」

a pair of = 兩件彼此對應、通常一起使用或視為一組的物件

Chinese depends on the object:

- pair of shoes = 一雙鞋
- pair of socks = 一雙襪

- pair of earrings = 一對耳環
 - pair of headphones = 一副耳機
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2. a pair of + one object with two joined parts (雙部件物品) — 一把／一條／一副

This is a very important grammar point.

Some English nouns are plural because the object has **two joined symmetrical parts**.

Examples:

- scissors
- trousers
- glasses
- binoculars

Practice 4

“I need a **pair of scissors**.”

「我需要一把剪刀。」

Practice 5

“He bought a new **pair of trousers**.”

「他買了一條新長褲。」

a pair of + plural-only object = 一件由兩個對稱／相連部分組成的完整物件

So **pair** here does not necessarily mean two separate objects.

3. pair = two people together (兩個人) — 一對；兩人一組

Practice 6

“The students worked in **pairs**.”

「學生們兩人一組工作。」

Practice 7

“A **pair** of tourists asked for directions.”

「一對／兩名一起的旅客問路。」

pair = 兩個人因活動、關係或安排而被視為一組

4. **pair** = romantic couple (伴侶／情侶) — 一對；一雙

Practice 8

“They make a lovely **pair**.”

「他們真是很登對的一對。」

Practice 9

“The young **pair** got married last year.”

「那對年輕伴侶去年結婚了。」

pair = 兩名具有戀愛／伴侶關係而被視為一對的人

This is a contextual branch of the “two people together” sense.

5. **pair** = two animals together (動物) — 一對；一雙

Practice 10

“A **pair of swans** was swimming on the lake.”

「一對天鵝在湖上游泳。」

Practice 11

“The birds usually form a **pair** during the breeding season.”

「這些鳥在繁殖季節通常會形成一對配偶。」

pair = 兩隻因配偶、活動或共同用途而被視為一組的動物

6. **pair** = two things that match/complement each other (相配物件) —— 一對; 配對

Practice 12

“These two lamps make a perfect **pair**.”

「這兩盞燈非常相配，是完美的一對。」

Practice 13

“The cups were sold as a **pair**.”

「這兩隻杯以一對形式出售。」

pair = 兩件在外觀、用途、設計或功能上互相配合的東西

7. **pair** = two cards of the same rank (撲克牌) —— 一對

A genuine game-specific meaning.

Practice 14

“I had a **pair of kings**.”

「我手上有一對 K。」

Practice 15

“A **pair** beats a high card.”

「在撲克中，一對勝過單張高牌。」

pair — cards = 兩張點數／牌面等級相同的牌

8. **pair = ordered pair / mathematical pair** (數學) — 數對；有序對

Practice 16

“The point can be represented by the ordered **pair** (3, 5).”

「這個點可以用有序數對 (3, 5) 表示。」

Practice 17

“Each input-output **pair** is recorded.”

「每組輸入與輸出的配對都會被記錄。」

pair — mathematics = 由兩個元素組成並被視為一個單位的組合；在有序對中順序具有意義

9. **pair + A and B (動詞)** — 把.....配成一對； 配對

Now **pair** is a verb.

Practice 18

“The teacher **paired** the students for the activity.”

「老師把學生兩人配成一組進行活動。」

Practice 19

“The socks were **paired** before being packed.”

「襪子在包裝前先被配成一雙。」

pair = 把兩個人／物按照某種關係或用途組合成一對

10. **pair A with B** (人／事物) — 把 A 與 B 配搭

Practice 20

“The app **pairs beginners with experienced users.**”

「這個應用程式會把新手與有經驗的使用者配對。」

Practice 21

“The designer **paired** dark wood **with** soft fabric.”

「設計師把深色木材與柔軟布料配搭在一起。」

pair A with B = 有意把兩個人／事物組合，讓它們一起工作、使用或呈現

11. **pair + devices** (科技) — 配對；建立無線連接

A very important modern technology meaning.

Practice 22

“You need to **pair** the headphones with your phone.”

「你需要把耳機和手機配對連接。」

Practice 23

“The speaker **paired** automatically with my laptop.”

「揚聲器自動與我的手提電腦完成配對。」

pair devices = 讓兩部裝置建立經認證／設定的無線連接，使它們可以互相通訊

Common with:

- Bluetooth
 - headphones
 - speakers
 - watches
 - controllers
-

12. pair + food/drink/flavours (食物／飲品／味道) — 配搭; 搭配

Practice 24

“This cheese **pairs well with** red wine.”

「這種芝士和紅酒很搭配。」

Practice 25

“The chef **paired** the fish with a light sauce.”

「廚師把魚配上清淡醬汁作搭配。」

pair food/drink = 把味道互相協調、能彼此提升的食物或飲品配在一起

This is very common in food writing.

13. pair = combine two people for work/activity (合作) — 配搭; 組成二人組

Practice 26

“The manager **paired** two designers on the project.”

「經理安排兩名設計師搭檔合作這個項目。」

Practice 27

“Participants were **paired** for the exercise.”

「參與者被安排兩人一組進行練習。」

pair people = 安排兩人共同進行某項活動、任務或工作

14. pairing = combination of two people/things (名詞) — 配對; 搭配; 組合

Practice 28

“The **pairing** of comfort and good sound quality made the product attractive.”

「舒適度和良好音質的結合／搭配令產品更吸引。」

Practice 29

“The unusual food **pairing** worked surprisingly well.”

「這個不尋常的食物搭配出奇地合適。」

pairing = 兩個人／事物被有意組合在一起的關係或組合本身

15. pairing = device connection process (科技) — 配對程序; 連接配對

Practice 30

“Bluetooth **pairing** took only a few seconds.”

「藍牙配對只花了幾秒鐘。」

Practice 31

“Put the headphones into **pairing mode**.”

「把耳機切換到配對模式。」

pairing — technology = 兩部裝置互相識別並建立連接關係的過程

16. pair programming (軟件開發) — 結對編程

A useful modern compound.

Practice 32

“The developers used **pair programming**.”

「開發人員採用了結對編程。」

Practice 33

“Pair programming allows two developers to work on the same code together.”

「結對編程讓兩名開發人員共同處理同一份程式碼。」

pair programming = 兩名程式設計員一起處理同一項編程工作, 通常一人操作、一人檢視／思考

17. pairwise = considered two at a time (數學／電腦／分析) — 成對地；兩兩之間的

A useful but more technical family member.

Practice 34

“The researchers made **pairwise comparisons** between the groups.”

「研究人員對各組進行兩兩比較。」

Practice 35

“The distances were calculated **pairwise**.”

「距離以兩兩配對方式計算。」

pairwise = 每次取兩個元素進行比較、關係分析或計算的

Register: academic / mathematics / computing.

Important distinction: pair vs couple

These overlap, but not perfectly.

pair

emphasizes:

- two that belong together;
- match;
- function as a unit.

“a pair of shoes”

couple

often simply means:

- two;
- a romantic pair.

“a couple of minutes”

= 幾分鐘／兩三分鐘

Normally:

a pair of shoes ✓

a couple of shoes ⚠

The second would usually mean two individual shoes, not necessarily one matching pair.

Important distinction: pair vs set

pair

= exactly two.

set

= a group of two or more items belonging together.

“a pair of headphones”

= 一副耳機

“a set of speakers”

= 一套揚聲器

A pair can be a type of set, but a set does not have to contain two items.

Important distinction: pair vs match

pair

= put two things together / two things considered as a unit.

match

= be similar, compatible, or suitable together.

“Pair these socks.”

「把襪子配成雙。」

“These socks match.”

「這些襪子很相配。」

You can **pair two things that do not match**.

Important distinction: pair vs two

two

simply gives the number.

a pair

adds the idea that the two belong together or function as a unit.

“two shoes”

could be two unrelated shoes.

“a pair of shoes”

means two corresponding shoes forming one usable set.

Important distinction: a pair of headphones vs two headphones

This is directly relevant to your passage.

a pair of headphones

= one complete headphone unit/set.

two pairs of headphones

= two complete headphone sets.

Saying:

“two headphones”

can be ambiguous and may sound as though you mean two complete units, but **pair(s) of headphones** is clearer for counting sets.

Important distinction: pair with vs connect to

Especially in technology.

pair with

means establish an authenticated/recognized device relationship, especially Bluetooth.

connect to

is broader:

the device may connect via:

- Bluetooth
- cable
- Wi-Fi
- network
- USB

So:

“Pair the headphones with your phone.”

is specifically about the pairing process.

After pairing:

“The headphones connect automatically.”

Important distinction: pair well with vs go well with

For food/style:

“This wine pairs well with fish.”

and:

“This wine goes well with fish.”

Both mean the combination is good.

pair well with sounds slightly more deliberate and is especially common in:

- food
 - wine
 - design
 - fashion
-

Grammar/countability note

One set:

a pair of headphones

The verb often agrees with **pair**:

“This pair of headphones **is** expensive.”

Multiple sets:

“Two pairs of headphones **are** on the table.”

So:

pair is the grammatical head of the phrase.

Family-extension sweep

After the full sweep, the useful modern family includes:

- **a pair of matching objects** = 一雙／一對／一副
- **a pair of scissors/trousers/etc.** = 一件由兩個相連部分組成的物件
- **pair — people** = 兩人／一組／一對
- **pair — romantic couple** = 一對伴侶

- **pair — animals** = 一對動物／配偶
- **pair — matching objects** = 相配的一對
- **pair — cards** = 同點數兩張牌／一對
- **pair — mathematics** = 數對／有序對
- **pair — verb** = 把兩人／物配成一對
- **pair A with B** = 把 A 與 B 搭配
- **pair devices** = 裝置配對
- **pair food/drink** = 味道搭配
- **pairing** = 配對／搭配／組合
- **pairing — technology** = 裝置配對過程
- **pair programming** = 結對編程
- **pairwise** = 兩兩之間的／成對地

There is also **unpair** in modern device language:

“Unpair the headphones from the phone.”

= 解除耳機與手機的配對

That is genuinely useful enough to flag as a family extension, though not another meaning of bare **pair**.

Family-extension note: unpair

unpair + devices — 解除配對

“You may need to **unpair** the headphones before connecting them to another device.”

「在連接另一部裝置之前，你可能需要先解除耳機原有的配對。」

unpair = 移除兩部裝置之間已建立的配對關係

Master comparison

Form / sense

MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning

a pair of matching objects 兩件互相對應、通常一起使用並被視為一組的物件

a pair of scissors/trousers/etc.	一件由兩個對稱／相連部分構成、語法上使用複數名詞的完整物件
pair — people	因活動、關係或安排而被視為一組的兩個人
pair — romantic couple	具有伴侶／戀愛關係而被視為一對的兩人
pair — animals	因配偶、繁殖或共同活動而被視為一對的動物
pair — matching objects	外觀、用途、設計或功能互相配合的兩件物品
pair — cards	兩張牌面等級相同的牌
pair — mathematics	由兩個元素組成並視為一個單位的數學組合
pair — verb	把兩個人／物按照用途或關係組合成一對
pair A with B	有意把兩個人／事物組合，使其共同工作、使用或呈現
pair devices	讓兩部電子裝置互相識別並建立配對連接
pair food/drink	把味道互相協調、能彼此提升的食物／飲品搭配
pairing — general	兩個人／事物被組合在一起的關係或組合本身
pairing — technology	兩部裝置互相識別並建立配對連接的過程
pair programming	兩名程式設計員共同處理同一項編程工作的協作方式
pairwise	每次取兩個元素進行比較、分析或計算的
unpair	移除兩部裝置之間原本建立的配對關係

For your original phrase

“a pair of noise-cancelling headphones”

The exact meaning is:

pair = 由左右兩邊耳機部分共同組成、被視為一整套的單一耳機裝置

So naturally:

a pair of headphones

= 一副耳機

And the key learner point is:

one pair of headphones = 一副耳機

two pairs of headphones = 兩副耳機

—not “two individual earpieces.”